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MARKETING

What is Generative Engine Optimization: The Rise of Zero-Click Culture

By Donna Talarico

SEO. Those three letters are so common that we in the marketing world rarely even spell out “search engine optimization” anymore. But there are three new letters on the block: GEO.

Generative Engine Optimization is similar to its predecessor, only it focuses on raising visibility within AI-powered platforms like ChatGPT instead of traditional search engines. Like

SEO, optimizing for these generative tools helps users find what they’re looking for (and what we, as colleges and universities, want them to find).

GEO strategy is an increasingly significant area of opportunity for brands and organizations of all kinds, and higher education institutions should be paying attention. The good news is that schools doing SEO well already have an excellent foundation on which to build their GEO expertise.

Shifting habits, shifting focus

The big difference between SEO and GEO is what happens next. In traditional search engines like Google, users might look through the first page of results, find a link, and click through to a specific URL. Today, AI summaries pull in information, often providing users with a bite-sized answer — without the need to visit a page. This shift in how results are delivered (and how people engage with the information) is referred to as the “zero-click culture.”

This is even more so the case when users bypass traditional search engines and instead strike up a conversation within their own generative chat tool of choice. On the surface, we have less control over (and less data about) what these results look like and what actions users take next.



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Preparing for zero-click users

In last month's column, I shared some takeaways from a spring conference I attended. One that really stuck with me — and was covered in a few different sessions — was how it's more important than ever to know what third-party sites are saying about our schools.

AI summaries and chatbots alike are known to reference Wikipedia, Reddit, and college rankings sites. It's worth mentioning that people often go to these sites because they cannot find what they're looking for within our own .edu properties.

While content on those sites isn't always controllable, it's crucial to monitor the sites to find opportunities for clarification and correction. This gives us a chance to reinforce our own websites as a single source of truth — and reminds us to continually optimize the digital properties we own. With stronger content that answers questions people are looking for, we have a better chance of being the trusted point of reference for AI-powered search.

A few GEO tips

While the algorithm is ever-changing and new ways of searching continue to be introduced, we can focus on several things within our own web content.

- Anticipate user questions and answer them in a structured

and prominent way, such as using headings/subheadings and short paragraphs; in other words, write them in the style of a Google "snippet."

- Favor clarity over cleverness in page and paragraph headings; while top-level pages on your site may benefit from sizzling, on-brand copy, deeper transactional pages should use index-style labels (like "how to do XYZ") to help search engines find relevant copy.

- Don't bury the lede; in the past, it was common practice to build value before giving information like tuition; users will be searching for it, so prepare your content so that your website shows up first.

- Continue to analyze your search data and web engagement; while there's not ready access to what is showing up in people's individual chatbot sessions, we should make good use of the data we have to uncover what's working — and what's not.

All of this should start with a solid website audit to find outdated and contradictory information — and a good governance plan to stay on top of things as time goes on.

In summary, good content is still king. Despite changing search behavior and consumer preferences, accurate and relevant information is vital. Your website could and should remain the most authoritative source of information about your institution. ■

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to life stories.

- Institutional support for relational labor. Acknowledge and respect the work of those who contributed to a better campus culture doing the invisible work of relational labor. That work involves mentoring, mediating, and emotionally supporting students and colleagues as integral to the educational work.

Humble Commitment to Growth

This shift from empathy to compassion isn't necessarily convenient. It requires vulnerability, patience, and the kind of situations in and of themselves that can not only put off the

rushing gears of institutional life. My time in higher education has convinced me that others have the ability to change, to extend themselves to one another, and to understand one another more profoundly when supportive conditions exist. Fostering those conditions isn't optional; it's at the core of serving as educators, mentors, and community builders. When our empathy falters, we must refuse to quit and instead turn it into a compassion that's intentional, brave, and expansive. By doing so, we honor the emotional life of those we serve while also embodying the greater ideals of justice, dignity, and shared humanity that constitute the heart of our educational mission. ■

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"My years of exposure to different people and different contexts would make me think that a person who looks like X, Y or Z would speak to me in a particular way, and I have to check all of that every time I walk into a patient's room.

"Professors, instructors, advisors all need to understand and not feel bad for that but acknowledge it so that we

can consciously counteract it," she adds. "We don't have to upend our world, but just understand that bias is there, understand and believe these differences in treatments are real so that we can both validate when somebody shares something with us and support people when they have difficult circumstances." ■